

ON AN ISLE OF SKULLS

Once the Home of a Vigorous Race of
Indians.

FILLED WITH SCIENTIFIC TREASURES

The Last Survivor on the Channel
Islands, Off the California Coast,
Has Now Been Dead Over
Forty Years.

POMONA, Cal., Nov. 30.—An expedition of scientific students has been made up, in Los Angeles and Pomona Valley, to explore thoroughly the Channel Islands, off the coast of that part of California, during the next six months, in the interests of archaeology. The party is to be sustained by Leland Stanford Junior University and Harvard

ology. The party is to be sustained by Leeland Stanford Junior University and Harvard University. Anthropological and archaeological scholars who have spent several weeks on these islands say they are one of the very richest fields for work in that department of knowledge on the Pacific coast.

The Channel Islands constitute California's only archipelago, with the possible exception of the rocky and scanty Farallone Islands. The former have been objects of romantic legends, curiosity, and mystery for a generation or more. Notwithstanding all the islands are within eighty-two miles of the California shores, they are solitary and unfrequented, and years roll by, with visits to them of less than twenty people annually. Each island has its own particular, strange, uncanny traditions, and each has countless traces of an occupation by thousands and thousands of Indians. When Juan Rodriguez Cabrillo, the Portuguese navigator, sailed up the coast of California, in 1542, he stopped for a day or two at each of the Channel Islands, and his records bear testimony that on the islands of Santa Barbara, Catalina, San Clemente, and San Nicolas there was "a vigorous and lusty race of natives, who thronged the shores of the little bays and headlands," and gazed in mute wonder at the white-sailed ships of the

the bays and headlands," and gazed in mute wonder at the white-sailed ships of the navigators. To-day the islands stand as they did over 350 years ago, but the natives are only a memory, represented by immense quantities of stone implements, barrels of fine wampum, and literally cartloads of human bones.

San Nicolas Island, which lies eighty miles immediately opposite the little city of San Buenaventura (recently called by the more modern and easy name of Ventura) is the most interesting of all the Channel Islands from many points of view. As far back as the memory of any person in Southern California runs, hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides. Strange utensils of serpentine, sandstone, and steatite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the Franciscan padres in the Santa Barba Mission, learning that there were but sixteen of the strange and almost extinct Indian race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and, one of the frequent storms of the Channel Islands springing up, the

sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conceptio and all on board were lost.

Sixteen years later, Capt. George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt sea otter off San Nicolas. On landing they were, like Crusoe, astonished, to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea. It was two years thereafter that the adventurous Captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw, on the surf-beaten shore, a woman with long, tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of colored birdskins, and scraping, with a bone knife, the blubber from a seal. They surrounded and approached her stealthily, and, although suddenly confronted, she did not appear in the least afraid, but smiled, and then, falling on her knees, prayed to the sun. The wild woman offered no objection when, by signs, she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

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rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr. S. L. Shaw, now eighty years old, and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen nor heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotion to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of the rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race forever. In speaking of that death, at a meeting of the Southern California Medical Society the other day, Dr. Walter Lindley said that if the woman could have been spared a few years of life, a story of one of the strangest races that ever lived in the Southwest, and that had had no contamination with the whites, might have been learned. The woman, known as the "Lone Woman of San Nicolas," has been the subject of a score of romances and poems, and food for a lot of philosophy on the Pacific coast for years.

San Nicolas is ten miles long and four miles wide at the widest point. Its topography shows a nearly level plateau with an elevation of 800 to 1,000 feet. Two-thirds of the surface is covered with drifting sand, and on the remainder grows a species of nutritious grass and moss, on which 1,000 sheep find pasture. Several springs have been discovered, but their water is slightly brackish. Of late years the island has rarely been visited, except by sheep shearers and shell gatherers, who make annual trips in schooners, fishing smacks, and Chinese junks.

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The only safe landing ground at San Nicolas is at Coral Harbor, a pretty cove formed by two sandstone arms thrust out from the main barrier of the shore. The entrance is only six or seven yards across, and the water within is as placid as a lake and sufficiently deep to float a vessel of twenty tons' burden. On the bleak, silvery strip of beach, immense white pelicans are to be seen at almost any season in the year, promenading with a stately dignity. On the approach of the dinghy they spread their heavy, pointed wings and vanish over the rocks. Further up the slope of the beach there is a dilapidated shearing shed and a weather-worn shanty belonging to Chinese shell gatherers, who haunt these lonely cliffs during late Summer and Fall.

Nothing more desolate than the general appearance of the island can be imagined. As far as the eye can trace, there are barren levels, with innumerable circular depressions, showing where primitive dwellings once stood. Not a vestige remains of the materials used in the construction of these rancherias. Hundreds of shell mounds are scattered about, and are found to consist of astonishing numbers of mollusks, the bones of every species of fish found in the channel, skeletons of seals, sea elephants, whales, sea otter, the island fox, and various aquatic birds. Without question, these animals were used for food by the tribes that once thronged these boundaries. There are also numerous canine

skeletons, several of which indicate a species of bull terrier. Judging from the immense quantities of dead land mollusks everywhere, there must have been a time when the island supported luxuriant vegetation. Of all this verdure nothing is seen to-day but a few stunted thorn bushes, and now and then a cactus, forlornly reaching its grotesque arms out of the interminable sweeps of sand.

An examination of some of the mounds discloses all sorts of curious utensils, stone cooking pots, water ollas, mortars, pestles, drills, bone needles and fish hooks, shell beads, charm stones, pipes, cups, and a few arrowheads, spear points, and swords made of bone. The absence of many weapons proves the peaceful attributes of the islanders. Small imitations of boats and fish, carved from crystallized talc and serpentine, also show a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture. In many places conical piles of small black pebbles contrast oddly with the white sand. In some instances these pebbles were closely packed in abalone shells. No trace is seen of the "brush pens," in which the lone woman of San Nicolas for years found her only shelter from the cutting wind and sand. Nature, ever unmindful of the individual, long since merged the efforts of this courageous life into the universal fate of an entire race. Indeed, every foot of this strange island is eloquent of the extinction of an almost unheard-of people.

A trip along the west coast of San Nicolas Island over a vast extent of shell mounds sets one to wondering how it was possible for a limited population to consume such prodigious numbers of mollusks. In fact, the infinite variety of mollusca on San Nicolas is said by biologists not to be exceeded by any other known region of equal area. The

is said by biologists not to be exceeded by any other known region of equal area. The shore line is of coarse sandstone, burrowed by the pounding surf into fantastic alcoves, bridges, columns, and caves. Sometimes these savage cuts form rude effigies bearing a surprising likeness to living creatures. One of the most conspicuous is the exact counterpart of the neck, breast, and body of a bird with an alert, hooded head. This piece of nature's sculpturing must be forty feet long, and, beheld from a distance, looks quite as perfect as if fashioned by man. There are hundreds of photographs of the freak of nature sold all over California.

Going westward from this gnawed, surf-lashed wall the ground makes a gentle descent to a wide mesa, terminating in a steep escarpment. The atmosphere from this elevation is so deliciously clear that the eye can readily distinguish the peak tops of all the Channel Islands, several of them being forty miles away. Immediately at one's feet there stretches away a dreary desert of stupendous barrenness. A singular characteristic of the place were heaps of the bones of whales, their arrangement and packing so systematically correct as to have withstood a century's sweep of winds over this exposed point. But one human skeleton has ever been found here, its bleached, dismembered aspect in keeping with the driven desolateness of the spot. The merciless blast had piled the sand dunes all about, but spread no kindly drift over this "rough sketch of man." All around are the casts of roots of trees in the shifting sand, ranging all the way in size from coarse fibre to several inches in diameter. These semi-petrifications are intact, the wind having swept them clean of the loose earth. They yield a metallic ring when tapped with a rock or shell. A still more remarkable feature of this desert is a sparse stone forest, the broken columns or trunks of trees composed of indurated sand.

sparse stone forest, the broken columns or trunks of trees composed of indurated sand. At the extreme west end of the island there is a colossal precipice 1,000 feet in height, its chasmed and slitted face softened by a luxuriant growth of emerald moss and lichens.

The most gruesome of all the sights on this strange island is to be seen on the broad plateau south of the Chinese camp, at Coral Harbor. Here acres of the naked sand are littered with hundreds of disjointed skeletons, and present the most reckless illustration of the "ground plan" of humanity that imagination can picture. Measurements have been made by several scientists of the thigh, leg, and arm bones, and literally bushels of skulls and other parts of the human frame have been brought to Los Angeles from San Nicolas Island for investigation. The general opinion is that the physiques of the Indian race that swarmed over the island then were much larger than those of any civilized race of to-day, and that some of them must have been 7 feet 3 inches tall. The skulls of this extinct tribe often measure several inches more than some of the large skulls of to-day. Many skulls found lying about on the island show that their possessors must have suffered death from a club or blunt battle axe. No one has yet found a skull on San Nicolas that shows marks of a bullet. There are many collar bones and shoulder blades broken and crushed, so that it is evident their owners were killed by some instrument, as a war club or boulder. Scientists say the favorite weapon in warfare with the Aleutian savage tribes a century or more ago was a club or bludgeon, and this fact fits with the stray tradition that the Aleutians came down and completely destroyed the people on the Channel Islands about 1780.
